NOT REPLACED, BUT AUGMENTED

Find Your Place in the Age of AI, Whoever You Are

Pouria Keshtidar

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The characters Lena, Amara, Karim and Jonas are fictional. Any resemblance to real persons is coincidental.

This book is intended for general information and orientation. It does not constitute individual career, legal, financial, medical or psychological advice. The author accepts no liability for decisions made on the basis of this book. Labour market figures were checked against the sources listed at the end of the book in October 2026 and may have changed since.

AI tools were used in the creation of this book.

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A Note Before We Begin

I am a computer science student, and a while ago I started to feel lost.

Every week there was a new headline about what AI could suddenly do. Write code. Pass exams. Design logos. Answer customers. I looked at the skills I was spending years learning and asked myself a question I didn't like: *Is any of this still going to matter?*

Then I noticed something: I wasn't the only one. Many people around me felt exactly the same. And it isn't only students. Nurses, designers, office workers and small business owners are asking themselves the same question about their own work. Different lives, same question.

That is why I wrote this book. Not because I have all the answers, but because I wanted to find the most honest ones I could, and share them with everyone who is asking the same question.

This book does not try to scare you, and it does not try to sell you a fantasy. It tries to help you see clearly, figure out where *you* stand, and take the next step. Whoever you are, whatever you do.

I hope it helps you the way writing it helped me.

Pouria Keshtidar

How This Book Works

Most books about the future of work talk to an imaginary average reader. But there is no average reader. A student who is applying for a first job, a nurse with fifteen years of experience and the owner of a small restaurant face very different situations. So this book is built to adapt to you.

Your AI Compass

In Chapter 1, you will take a short self-assessment called the **AI Compass**. It takes about five minutes. It looks at two things: how much of your work is exposed to what AI can already do, and how actively you are engaging with the change. From that, you get one of four profiles:

- **The Watcher**: steady, grounded, not yet very involved.
- **The Worrier**: sees the change clearly, but feels stuck.
- **The Explorer**: curious and experimenting, sometimes scattered.
- **The Navigator**: right in the middle of the change and actively steering.

None of the profiles is better or worse than the others. Each comes with real strengths and a typical blind spot. And none of them is permanent. The whole point of this book is to help you move.

From then on, every chapter contains a box called **Your Compass**, with specific advice for each of the four profiles.

Read the advice for your own profile first. Then, if you are curious, read the others. You will often learn something about the people around you.

Four companions

Throughout the book, you will follow four people:

- **Lena**, 23, a computer science student close to graduating, whose applications keep getting rejected.
- **Amara**, 34, a nurse on a busy hospital ward, who is sure AI has nothing to do with her work.
- **Karim**, 52, the owner of a small family restaurant, who loves trying every new app on his phone.
- **Jonas**, 29, a freelance graphic designer, whose clients have started using AI image tools themselves.

Their stories open each chapter and cross each other along the way. Lena, Amara, Karim and Jonas are fictional. They are composites, built from situations that many real people are facing right now. You may recognise yourself in one of them, or in a little of each.

Missions

Each chapter contains one or two **Missions**: short, concrete exercises you can usually complete in under an hour. In the print edition, there is space to write directly in the book. If you are reading the ebook, keep a notebook or a document open next to you.

The missions are the most important part of this book. Reading about change feels productive. Doing something

small is what actually changes your situation. At the end of the book, you will find a **Mission Log** where you can tick off every mission you have completed.

A word on facts

Wherever this book makes claims about AI or the job market, it relies on published research and official statistics, not on headlines. The sources are listed at the end. Much of the most detailed data comes from the United States, because large labour datasets are most accessible there; local conditions differ, so always check the numbers for your own country and field. And because the situation moves fast, treat every number as a snapshot, not a prophecy. The goal is not to memorise figures but to learn how to read them.

How to read

You can read from start to finish, which is what I recommend for the first time. But if something is urgent:

- If you mostly feel anxious, go to **Chapter 4**.
- If you want the facts first, read **Chapters 2 and 3**.
- If you are applying for jobs right now, read **Chapter 9**.
- If you just want to start doing something, take the Compass in **Chapter 1** and jump to **Chapter 10**.

Let's begin by finding out where you stand.

PART ONE

Where Do You Stand?

CHAPTER 1

Your AI Compass

STORY · LENA

It was the forty-third rejection email. Lena knew the number because she had started counting, which she now realised was a mistake.

Thank you for your interest. After careful consideration, we have decided to move forward with other candidates.

She closed the laptop and looked around the kitchen of the small restaurant where she worked three evenings a week. Karim, the owner, was standing by the counter, holding his phone at arm's length and squinting at it.

"Lena! Come here. Look at this. I asked the app to write a description for the lamb stew, and listen: *A soulful embrace of slow-cooked tenderness.*" He laughed. "Soulful embrace! My mother would hit me with a spoon."

Lena tried to smile. "It's not bad, actually."

"It's terrible. But it's fast." Karim looked at her more closely. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing. It's just..." She hesitated. "I spent four years learning to do things that this app on your phone does in five seconds. And now nobody wants to hire me."

Karim put the phone down. He didn't say anything clever. He just pulled out a chair, poured her a glass of tea and sat down opposite her.

> "Okay," he said. "Tell me where you stand. Not where the news says everybody stands. Where *you* stand."

That is the question this chapter asks you, too. Not where *people* stand, or *students*, or *workers in general*. Where you stand.

It sounds simple, but most of us never answer it properly. We absorb headlines, compare ourselves with others and end up with a vague feeling, often anxiety, sometimes indifference. A vague feeling is a bad basis for decisions. So let's replace it with something more useful: a map.

Two questions that matter

When researchers study how AI affects work, two factors keep appearing. You will see the evidence in Chapter 3. For now, here is the short version.

The first factor is exposure. How much of your work consists of tasks that AI can already do reasonably well? Work that happens mostly on a screen, involves writing, coding, summarising, designing or analysing, and follows recognisable patterns is highly exposed. Work that requires physical presence, hands-on care, unpredictable real-world situations or deep personal relationships is less exposed.

Exposure is not destiny. High exposure does not mean your job will disappear; it means your job is likely to *change* faster. Low exposure does not mean you are safe forever; it means the change may arrive later, or more quietly.

The second factor is engagement. How actively are you dealing with the change? Do you try new tools, learn new skills and adjust how you work? Or are you watching from a distance, either because you feel it doesn't concern you or because it feels too overwhelming to touch?

Exposure is largely determined by your field. Engagement is largely determined by you. That is good news, because it means half of the map is in your hands.

Taking the Compass

The AI Compass consists of twelve statements. Rate each statement from **1** (not true at all for me) to **5** (completely true for me). Don't think too long. Your first instinct is usually the most honest answer.

If you are a student or currently not working, answer Part A for the kind of work you are aiming for.

Part A: Your work

1. A large part of my work happens on a computer or other screen.	1	2	3	4	5
2. My work involves a lot of writing, summarising, translating or editing text.	1	2	3	4	5
3. I regularly produce code, designs, analyses or reports based on clear instructions.	1	2	3	4	5
4. Many of my tasks follow similar patterns from week to week.	1	2	3	4	5
5. Most of what I do could be explained in a detailed manual.	1	2	3	4	5

6. I rarely need to be physically present with people or objects to do my work.	1	2	3	4	5

Part A total (6–30)

Part B: Your approach

7. I have used an AI tool at least once in the past week.	1	2	3	4	5
8. When a new tool or technology appears, I usually try it out myself.	1	2	3	4	5
9. I have already changed something about how I work or learn because of AI.	1	2	3	4	5
10. I could explain to a friend what AI is good at and what it is bad at.	1	2	3	4	5
11. I am actively learning something new for my career right now.	1	2	3	4	5
12. When I think about AI and my future, I feel more curious than afraid.	1	2	3	4	5

Part B total (6–30)

Finding your profile

Add up your scores for each part. Each total will be between 6 and 30.

- A Part A score of **18 or more** means **high exposure**. Below 18 means **lower exposure**.
- A Part B score of **18 or more** means **high engagement**. Below 18 means **lower engagement**.

Now find your profile:

- **Lower exposure + lower engagement:** you are a **Watcher**.
- **High exposure + lower engagement:** you are a **Worrier**.
- **Lower exposure + high engagement:** you are an **Explorer**.
- **High exposure + high engagement:** you are a **Navigator**.

If one of your scores is exactly 17, 18 or 19, you are close to a border. Read the descriptions of both neighbouring profiles and choose the one that feels more true. Borders are normal. People are not boxes.

My Compass profile

The four profiles

The Watcher

"This doesn't really concern me. Not yet, anyway."

Watchers usually do work that is rooted in the physical world or in direct human contact, and they have not engaged much with AI so far. Many nurses, tradespeople, teachers, technicians and people in hospitality start here.

Strengths: Watchers are grounded. They are not swept away by hype, and their skills are often the hardest to automate. They have time to prepare calmly, which is a real advantage.

Blind spot: Lower exposure is not zero exposure. AI often enters these jobs quietly, through the paperwork, scheduling, documentation and communication that surround the core

work. Watchers risk being surprised, and they may miss tools that could make their work easier.

Your direction: Small, low-pressure experiments. You don't need to become an AI expert. You need to know enough to use what helps you and to recognise change early.

Your companion: Amara, the nurse.

The Worrier

"This is going to hit me hard, and I don't know what to do about it."

Worriers do, or are aiming for, work that is highly exposed, and they feel it. They read the headlines, they see what the tools can do, and they feel a mixture of fear and paralysis. Many students in computer science, business, marketing, translation and design are here right now.

Strengths: Worriers see the situation clearly. Their concern is not irrational; it is a sign that they have understood something real. That sensitivity, once turned into action, becomes an advantage.

Blind spot: Fear makes people passive. Worriers often consume more and more information instead of doing anything with it. They also tend to compare themselves with others and assume everyone else is coping better.

Your direction: Turn fear into small, concrete actions. Separate what you can control from what you can't. Build one real thing.

Your companion: Lena, the student.

The Explorer

"This is fascinating. Let me try it!"

Explorers are curious. Their core work may not be very exposed, but they love trying new tools and ideas. Many small business owners, hobbyists and people in practical professions with a playful streak are here.

Strengths: Curiosity is one of the most valuable traits in times of change. Explorers learn fast, are not afraid of new things and often spot opportunities others miss.

Blind spot: Explorers can be scattered. They try ten tools and finish nothing. They may confuse playing with a technology with getting real value from it.

Your direction: Focus. Pick one or two real problems and go deep instead of wide. Turn experiments into results.

Your companion: Karim, the restaurant owner.

The Navigator

"I'm in the middle of this and I'm steering as fast as I can."

Navigators do highly exposed work and engage with AI actively. They use the tools daily and adapt quickly. Many developers, designers, writers, analysts and marketers who are already deep into AI tools are here.

Strengths: Navigators have skills, momentum and practical experience. They know what the tools can do because they use them.

Blind spot: Navigators can end up competing with the tool instead of rising above it: producing more and faster at lower prices, until the tool can do it without them. They also risk exhaustion from trying to keep up with every change.

Your direction: Move from *producing* to *judging, directing and owning*. Use AI to augment the parts of your work that only you can do, not just to speed up the parts that anyone can do.

Your companion: Jonas, the designer.

Your profile is a starting point, not a label

Two things are important to remember.

First, your profile describes where you stand *today*. It will change, and it should. Many people move from Worrier to Navigator, or from Watcher to Explorer, within a few months. At the end of this book, you will retake the Compass and see how far you have moved.

Second, no profile is "the right one". A calm Watcher who adapts at the right moment can do better than a stressed Navigator who burns out. The goal is not to reach a particular box. The goal is to move consciously instead of drifting.

> **STORY · KARIM AND LENA**
>
> Lena finished the twelve questions that Karim had scribbled on the back of an order pad. He had copied them from a book a customer had left behind.
>
> "Part A: twenty-six. Part B: eleven."
>
> "So, high exposure, low engagement," Karim said. "A Worrier."
>
> "Great. Even the quiz agrees I should worry."

"No, no." Karim tapped the paper. "It says you see the situation clearly. It says your problem is not that you are stupid or too late. Your problem is that you are standing still." He turned the paper around and filled it out himself. "Part A: nine. Part B: twenty-four. Explorer!" He beamed. "I knew it."

"It also says Explorers start ten things and finish none," Lena said.

Karim looked at the three half-finished apps on his phone, the unopened online course on social media marketing and the box of receipts he had meant to digitise for six months.

"Hm," he said. "Maybe the book has a point."

YOUR COMPASS

Watcher: Write down one part of your work that you find tedious or time-consuming: paperwork, scheduling, emails. That is where AI is most likely to enter your world first, and where it might help you most.

Worrier: Look at your Part B answers. Which statement could you raise by one point within the next week? Pick the easiest one. That is your first step.

Explorer: List every AI tool or experiment you have started in the past three months. Circle the one that produced a real, useful result. That is where you should go deeper.

Navigator: Look at your Part A answers. The statements you scored 5 describe the tasks most at risk of being

automated. Ask yourself honestly: is that where most of your value comes from today?

MISSION 1 · TAKE YOUR BEARINGS

Complete the AI Compass if you haven't already, and write down your scores and profile above.

Then answer these three questions in one or two sentences each:

1. Which part of the profile description fits me surprisingly well?
2. Which part does not fit at all?
3. Which profile would I like to have in ninety days, and why?

Key Takeaways

- Two factors matter most: how **exposed** your work is to AI, and how actively you **engage** with the change.
- Exposure is largely set by your field. Engagement is largely set by you.
- The four profiles, Watcher, Worrier, Explorer and Navigator, each have real strengths and a typical blind spot.
- Your profile is a starting point. The goal of this book is to help you move consciously.

PART TWO

See Clearly

CHAPTER 2

What AI Can Really Do – and What It Can't

STORY · AMARA

The email from hospital management arrived at the end of Amara's night shift. *Pilot project: AI-assisted documentation on Ward 4. Training session on Monday.*

She read it twice, then showed it to her colleague. "AI documentation. Wonderful. Next they'll send a robot to change the dressings."

On her way home she stopped at Karim's restaurant, as she often did after nights. Breakfast at seven in the morning was a strange habit, but Karim never asked questions and always made her eggs the way her grandmother used to.

"You look like someone ruined your day," Karim said.

"Someone is trying to put AI in my ward." She dropped into her usual chair. "As if a computer understands what it means when a patient is quiet in a way that's different from being asleep."

Lena, who was setting tables for the lunch shift, looked up. "What exactly is it supposed to do?"

"Listen to us during handover and write the notes automatically, apparently."

"Hm." Lena thought for a moment. "Honestly, that's the kind of thing it's actually good at. It won't understand your

patient. But it might save you an hour of typing."

Amara frowned. "An hour?"

"Maybe. Or it might write nonsense and cost you an hour of corrections. It depends."

"That's not very reassuring."

"No," Lena admitted. "But it's honest."

If you are afraid of something you don't understand, you are afraid of a shadow. Shadows tend to look bigger than the things that cast them. So before we talk about jobs, skills or plans, let's look at the thing itself.

MYTH OR FACT?

Before you read on, decide for each statement: myth or fact? The answers are at the end of this chapter.

1. AI systems know when they don't know something.
2. People who use AI tools every day tend to trust them completely.
3. AI is mainly a threat to jobs that involve physical work.
4. Even experts can feel faster with AI while actually being slower.
5. Whether AI replaces or strengthens a worker depends partly on how it is used.

Two stories, and why both are wrong

You will mostly meet two stories about AI.

The first: AI is a kind of super-brain. Within a few years, it will do almost every job better and cheaper than humans. Training, studying and building a career are pointless, because the machines will take over anyway.

The second: AI is just an overgrown autocomplete. It produces impressive-sounding text but understands nothing. It is a hype bubble, and soon everything will go back to normal.

Both stories are comfortable, because they are simple. The first gives us permission to panic and do nothing. The second gives us permission to look away and do nothing. Notice that the result is the same: standing still.

The truth is messier. AI systems are astonishingly strong in some areas, surprisingly weak in others, and the boundary keeps moving. That is exactly why it pays to look closely.

What we are actually talking about

When people say "AI" today, they usually mean large language models and the tools built on top of them. These systems have been trained on enormous amounts of text, code, images and other data, and have learned to reproduce the patterns in it with remarkable precision.

You don't need the mathematics to understand the practical consequence. A system that has absorbed patterns from a vast amount of human work can produce output that very often looks like what a competent human would produce. It can answer questions, summarise documents, translate, write

code, generate images and explain concepts. Newer systems can also use tools: search the web, run code, read files and work through sequences of steps on their own. These are often called *agents*.

That is a big deal. It would be dishonest to pretend otherwise.

What AI does well

- **Language work.** Drafting emails, summarising long documents, translating, changing tone or length, turning notes into structured text.
- **Code.** Writing functions, suggesting fixes, explaining unfamiliar code, converting between programming languages.
- **Images and design drafts.** Producing illustrations, variations, mock-ups and visual ideas in seconds.
- **Structuring knowledge.** Explaining topics at different levels, preparing study material, organising messy information.
- **Routine digital tasks.** Reformatting data, filling templates, analysing spreadsheets, preparing standard documents.
- **Transcription and documentation.** Turning spoken conversations into written notes, which is exactly what Amara's hospital is testing.
- **Availability.** It never gets tired, is never annoyed by your fifth follow-up question and is there at three in the morning.

What AI still does poorly

- **Reliability.** AI can state false things with great confidence and does not reliably know when it doesn't know. An answer can be ninety percent excellent and ten percent quietly wrong, and the wrong part is not marked.
- **Responsibility.** AI does not sign contracts, carry liability or stand in front of a patient, a customer or a manager when something goes wrong. Someone has to own the result.
- **The physical world.** Changing a dressing, fixing a pipe, cooking for a full restaurant on a Saturday night or calming a frightened child all require hands, presence and judgement in the moment.
- **Real-world context.** AI does not know the tensions in your team, the history of a customer relationship or why a patient is quiet in a way that is different from being asleep.
- **Asking the right question.** AI answers questions well. Figuring out which problem actually needs to be solved remains largely human work.
- **Trust.** People buy from people, work with people and follow people.

The professionals who use these tools most are well aware of their limits. In Stack Overflow's 2025 survey of software developers, more developers actively distrusted the accuracy of AI output than trusted it. In the 2026 survey, only a small minority said they would trust AI with an important decision. The people closest to the technology use it constantly, and check it constantly.

Tasks, not jobs

The most important mistake in the whole debate is the question: *"Will my job be replaced?"*

Jobs are not single things. They are bundles of tasks.

Amara does not just "do nursing". She assesses patients, gives medication, documents care, coordinates with doctors, comforts relatives, trains new colleagues, notices when something is wrong before the monitors do and spends a surprising part of every shift typing. AI could take over some of the typing. It will not notice the quiet patient.

Jonas does not just "make images". He listens to clients, figures out what their brand stands for, develops concepts, produces visuals, presents ideas and manages projects. AI can now produce many of the visuals. It cannot sit across from a client and understand what they really want.

Lena's future job as a developer will include clarifying requirements, reading other people's code, debugging, reviewing, explaining decisions and carrying responsibility when systems fail. AI already writes a lot of code. It does not own the outcome.

So the better question is: *Which parts of my work will be automated, which will be amplified, and which will become more important?* With that question, a vague fear turns into a concrete problem. And concrete problems can be worked on.

Automation and augmentation

Researchers increasingly distinguish two ways AI is used:

- **Automation:** AI does the task instead of a person.
- **Augmentation:** AI helps a person do the task better or faster, and the person stays at the centre.

This distinction turns out to be crucial. As the next chapter shows, the data suggests that where AI mainly automates, entry-level employment has come under pressure, while where it mainly augments, employment has held up or grown.

You cannot fully control which tasks your employer or your clients decide to automate. But you can strongly influence whether *you* are the person replaced by the tool or the person who uses the tool to do more. That difference runs through every chapter of this book.

Why the boundary keeps moving

What doesn't work today may work in a year. Systems that struggled with simple arithmetic a few years ago now solve competition-level problems. Tools that suggested single lines of code now edit entire projects. That is why any single prediction, optimistic or pessimistic, should be treated with caution.

A wiser stance is *active observation*: regularly trying the tools yourself instead of only reading opinions about them. People who use the tools develop a realistic feel for where they are strong and where they are not. That feel updates itself as the tools change, which no headline can do.

YOUR COMPASS

Watcher: Look for AI in the *edges* of your work: documentation, scheduling, emails, forms. That is where it usually arrives first in hands-on professions.

Worrier: Notice the list of weaknesses above. They are real. AI is not an all-powerful competitor; it is a powerful but unreliable tool that needs someone who understands the work.

Explorer: Move from "Wow, it can do that!" to "Is the result actually good enough to use?" Judge tools by the quality of their output, not by the surprise.

Navigator: Make a list of the tasks in your work that AI already does nearly as well as you. Then make a second list of tasks it cannot do. Your future value lives on the second list.

MISSION 2 · MAP YOUR TASKS

Choose three tasks you do regularly, for your studies, your job or your business. For each one:

1. Do it once without AI and note how long it takes.
2. Do it with an AI tool and note how long it takes, *including* the time to check and fix the result.
3. Write down what the AI did well, what it got wrong, and what only you could add.

Task	Time without AI	Time with AI (incl. checking)	What only I could add

ANSWERS: MYTH OR FACT?

1. **Myth.** AI systems often state wrong things with full confidence. Checking is your job.
2. **Myth.** Developer surveys show heavy use combined with widespread caution and limited trust.
3. **Myth.** The most exposed work today is mostly digital: writing, coding, analysis, design and customer communication.
4. **Fact.** A 2025 study found experienced developers were slower with AI on familiar projects, while believing they were faster. More in Chapter 6.
5. **Fact.** Research distinguishes automation from augmentation, with very different effects on employment. More in Chapter 3.

Key Takeaways

- AI is neither a super-brain nor a toy. It is a powerful but error-prone tool.
- Think in tasks, not jobs. Every job is a bundle of tasks that AI affects very differently.
- Whether AI automates or augments your work matters, and you can influence which side you are on.
- Try the tools yourself regularly instead of relying on other people's opinions.

CHAPTER 3

What the Data Says About Work

STORY · JONAS

The message from the client was polite. That made it worse.

Hi Jonas, thanks so much for the concepts. We played around with one of those AI tools in the meantime and came up with something we really like, so we won't need the rest of the project. We'll pay for the hours so far, of course!

Jonas looked at the attached image. It was... fine. Clean, colourful, generic. It looked like a thousand other logos. But the client liked it, and it had cost them nothing.

It was the third time this year. He had been using AI tools himself for months. He was faster than ever, producing more drafts, more variations, more options. And yet his clients were paying less, and some were leaving.

That evening he met Karim to talk about a new menu design. Karim had asked him to do the restaurant's logo five years ago and still paid him every time he needed a new flyer.

"You look like Amara after a night shift," Karim said.

Jonas showed him the client's message. Karim read it, then looked at the logo for a long time.

> "It's okay," Karim said finally. "But it's nobody's logo. Your logo for me, people recognise it from across the street. You asked me fifty questions before you drew anything. About my mother. About the old restaurant. About why I use blue plates."
>
> "Clients don't pay for questions," Jonas said.
>
> "Maybe," Karim said. "Or maybe that is the only thing they should pay you for."

Technological change rarely just destroys work. It moves it. That is no comfort to someone losing clients or getting rejection emails, but it is the frame in which the current situation has to be understood. This chapter looks at what the evidence actually shows: where it is clear, where it is unclear and what it means for different kinds of people.

How people feel about it

If you feel uneasy, you are in the majority. In a large survey by the Pew Research Center of more than 5,000 employed adults in the United States, conducted in late 2024, about half of workers said they felt **worried** about the future impact of AI in the workplace, and about a third felt **overwhelmed**. Only around a third felt **hopeful**.

At the same time, most workers in that survey said they did not use AI much or at all in their jobs yet. That combination, high concern and low hands-on experience, is exactly the Worrier and Watcher territory from Chapter 1. Fear grows fastest where direct experience is missing.

Lessons from earlier shifts

When spreadsheets arrived in offices in the 1980s, many expected the end of bookkeeping. What mostly disappeared was manual calculation, while demand for analysis, planning and financial advice grew. When the internet spread, many traditional sales channels collapsed, and at the same time entire professions appeared that nobody could have named beforehand.

The pattern tends to repeat. When an activity becomes cheaper, people often do more of it, and work moves to the parts that are still expensive, difficult or human.

But there is a flip side, often skipped in optimistic talks. Transitions are hard for the people in the middle of them. The skills of the bookkeeper did not automatically become the skills of the financial analyst. Some people adapted quickly; others lost years. Saying things work out "in the long run" doesn't help anyone who has to pay rent this month.

The big picture: churn, not collapse

One of the largest regular studies of employer expectations is the World Economic Forum's *Future of Jobs Report*. The 2025 edition surveyed more than a thousand large employers representing over fourteen million workers across many industries and economies.

Its projection for the period up to 2030 is heavy churn rather than collapse: around **170 million jobs created** and around **92 million displaced**, a net gain of about **78 million**. Roughly a fifth of today's jobs are expected to be affected. Employers also expect close to **40 percent** of the skills workers use today

to change by 2030.

Two cautions. These are employer expectations, not certainties. And a global net gain says nothing about whether *your* job, in *your* city, is among the growing or the shrinking ones. The value of the report lies in its direction: technology skills like AI, data and cybersecurity are expected to grow fastest in demand, while human skills such as analytical thinking, resilience, flexibility and creative thinking remain central. The people expected to do best combine both.

The entry level is under pressure

The clearest evidence of change so far comes from the very beginning of careers.

Researchers at Stanford University's Digital Economy Lab, led by economist Erik Brynjolfsson, have tracked payroll data from millions of US workers in a study called *Canaries in the Coal Mine?*. The title refers to the birds miners once carried underground because they reacted to dangerous gases before humans did. Young workers, the researchers suggest, may be the early warning signal.

In the revised version published in August 2026, they report:

- Employment of workers aged **22 to 25** in the most AI-exposed occupations now stands about **19 percent** below where it would be if it had kept pace with their peers in less-exposed occupations.
- In raw numbers, employment for this group in the most exposed occupations fell by about **11 percent** between late 2022 and mid-2026, while employment of the same age group in the least exposed occupations grew by about **10**

percent.

- The change happens mainly through **less hiring of young people**, not through more firing.
- Experienced workers in the same occupations show no comparable gap.
- The declines are concentrated where AI mainly **substitutes** for human tasks. Where AI mainly **complements** workers, employment is flat or rising.

The researchers describe these as early indicators, not proof of cause and effect. Interest rates and the general economy play a role too. But the pattern fits the idea that AI has begun to affect the jobs that used to be the first rung on the ladder.

Why young workers first? A likely explanation is the difference between **codified** and **tacit** knowledge. Much of what a new graduate brings is codified: knowledge from textbooks and lectures, exactly the kind AI has absorbed. Experienced workers bring more tacit knowledge: how this company works, which client needs careful handling, why a system behaves strangely, how to calm a tense meeting. That knowledge is rarely written down, so AI cannot easily copy it.

What graduates are experiencing

Official statistics paint a similar picture. The Federal Reserve Bank of New York tracks the US labour market for recent college graduates aged 22 to 27. In the second quarter of 2026, their unemployment rate was about **5.6 percent**, higher than for the workforce as a whole, and about **42 percent** were underemployed, working in jobs that typically don't require a degree. In the bank's breakdown by subject, computer science

and computer engineering have recently been among the fields with above-average unemployment for new graduates.

But the long-term outlook for an *occupation* can differ sharply from the short-term experience of a *new graduate*. The US Bureau of Labor Statistics projects employment of software developers, quality assurance analysts and testers to grow by about **10 percent** between 2025 and 2035, much faster than the 3 percent average for all occupations, with around **106,000 openings per year**. It names software for AI, security and the growing number of software-driven products as reasons.

Put simply: the on-ramp has become steeper, but the road has not disappeared.

What this means across different kinds of work

The research focuses heavily on office and technology jobs, because that is where AI exposure is highest. But the same logic applies elsewhere:

- **Hands-on professions** like nursing, trades, hospitality and care are less exposed in their core tasks. Change arrives first in the surrounding work: documentation, scheduling, ordering, customer communication. That can be a relief rather than a threat, if people learn to use it well.
- **Creative professions** like design, writing and photography are highly exposed in *production* but much less in *direction*: understanding the client, developing a concept, making choices that give work a recognisable identity.

- **Small businesses** gain access to capabilities that used to require specialists or agencies: marketing text, simple design, bookkeeping help, data analysis. The risk is not replacement but falling behind competitors who use these tools well.
- **Experienced professionals** in exposed fields are currently better protected than newcomers because of their tacit knowledge. But that protection depends on continuing to grow. Experience that stops developing turns into the next generation's codified knowledge.

Not every layoff is an AI layoff

Almost every change in the technology industry is now explained with AI. That is too simple. Interest rates, investment cycles, over-hiring in boom years, the general economy and company strategy all play a role. Some companies cite AI because it sounds more forward-looking than "we hired too many people". Others invest heavily in AI and hire specifically for it.

Don't stop at headlines. Look at which roles are actually being advertised, what job postings ask for and what recently hired people say.

Where demand is growing

When software and content become cheaper to produce, more of them get produced, and more people are needed to integrate, check, secure and direct them. Demand is growing in areas such as:

- **Integration:** connecting AI to real systems and processes in organisations.
- **Quality and security:** checking what machines produce. More generated output means more output that needs review.
- **Domain knowledge plus technology:** people who understand healthcare, law, logistics, energy, hospitality or finance *and* can apply technology to it.
- **Infrastructure and data:** the systems and data AI depends on.
- **Translation between worlds:** people who can explain technology to non-technical colleagues and business needs to technical teams.

STORY · JONAS

Jonas couldn't stop thinking about what Karim had said. That night, instead of producing more drafts for his remaining clients, he did something he hadn't done in months. He opened a spreadsheet and listed every project from the past two years: what he had been paid, how long it took and what the client had valued most.

The pattern was uncomfortable. The projects where he had been paid well were the ones where he had spent time understanding the client: workshops, interviews, long conversations. The projects where prices had dropped were the ones where he had simply delivered images.

"I've been racing the machine," he wrote in his notes. "And the machine is winning that race."

YOUR COMPASS

Watcher: Your core work is relatively protected, and that is a genuine advantage. Use the calm to prepare, not to ignore. Watch how AI enters the paperwork and coordination around your work.

Worrier: The data confirms your concern is real, especially at the entry level. But it also shows *where* things are better: wherever AI augments people. Your task is to become someone who is augmented, not replaced.

Explorer: Look for the intersection of your curiosity and real demand. Small businesses and hands-on fields need people who can apply these tools practically. That might be you.

Navigator: Look at Jonas. Speed alone is a race against the tool. Ask which of your tasks are being *substituted* and which are being *complemented*, and shift your time towards the second.

MISSION 3 · READ YOUR MARKET

Collect fifteen to twenty job postings, project requests or client briefs for the kind of work you do or want to do. If you run a business, look at what your competitors offer instead.

List the skills, tasks or qualities that appear again and again. Then mark which you already have and which you are missing.

Appears often	I have this	I'm missing this	Could build in 3 months

Key Takeaways

- Many workers feel worried about AI, often while having little hands-on experience with it.
- Global projections point to heavy churn rather than collapse, with growing demand for people who combine technical and human skills.
- Entry-level jobs in AI-exposed fields are under real pressure, mainly through reduced hiring.
- Where AI augments rather than replaces people, employment is holding up or growing.
- Different kinds of work are affected differently. Read your own market instead of trusting headlines.

CHAPTER 4

Taking the Fear Seriously

STORY · LENA AND AMARA

It was two in the morning, and Lena was on her fourteenth article about the future of work. *Ten jobs AI will eliminate by 2030. Why coding is dead. The developers who are already obsolete.* She knew she should stop. She didn't.

The next morning she came to the restaurant early, eyes red, and found Amara at her usual table with eggs and coffee, just off a night shift.

"You look worse than me," Amara said. "And I've been awake for twenty hours."

Lena laughed weakly and sat down. Before she knew it, she was telling Amara everything: the rejections, the articles, the feeling that everyone else had already figured it out.

Amara listened the way she listened to patients: without interrupting, without trying to fix things too quickly.

"Can I tell you what I see?" she said finally. "I see someone who hasn't slept, who has read a hundred opinions and done zero things. In my job, when a patient is panicking, we don't give them more information. We help them breathe, and then we find one thing they can do."

"Like what?"

"Like sleep tonight. And tomorrow, one thing. A small one."

Before we talk about skills and plans, we have to talk about something most career guides skip: the feeling. Someone who lies awake wondering whether their work still has a future will not become calmer because of a list of skills. Fear doesn't respond well to information alone. It needs to be understood, and then it needs action.

You are not alone, and you are not too late

The uncertainty you may feel is not a personal weakness. It is a reasonable reaction to a situation that is genuinely unclear. Students, career starters, experienced professionals and business owners are feeling it at the same time. Even people who build AI systems for a living openly say they don't know exactly how the coming years will unfold.

If the experts don't know, your uncertainty is not a sign that you have missed something everyone else understands. It is simply an accurate perception.

Uncertainty doesn't mean hopelessness. It only means that nobody knows the future precisely. That has always been true. Careers have always been shaped by recessions, new technologies, lucky encounters and unexpected changes. We just felt it less when change was slower.

What fear does to us

In small doses, fear is useful: it makes us pay attention and prepare. But chronic, diffuse fear has unhelpful effects:

- **It narrows our view.** We see threats everywhere and opportunities nowhere.

- **It makes us passive.** We freeze, postpone decisions and wait for a clarity that never comes.
- **It makes us consume instead of act.** We read article after article about the future of work instead of working on our own.
- **It distorts comparison.** Everyone else seems to be coping better.

Recognising these effects doesn't make them disappear. But it helps you notice when they are happening, so you can respond on purpose instead of on autopilot.

Fear looks different for each profile

The four Compass profiles tend to experience the change in different ways:

- **Watchers** often don't feel fear at all, or they push it away: *"This won't affect me."* That can be calm realism or quiet avoidance. The question is whether you are choosing not to engage, or avoiding something uncomfortable.
- **Worriers** feel fear most directly. It shows up as sleepless nights, endless scrolling, rejection taken personally and the sense of being too late.
- **Explorers** often channel nervous energy into activity: trying one more tool, starting one more project. That feels better than fear, but it can be a way of avoiding the harder question of direction.
- **Navigators** may feel pressure rather than fear: the exhausting sense that they have to keep up with everything, all the time, or fall behind.

Recognising your pattern is the first step to working with it rather than against it.

The comparison trap

Social media shows us people who seem to have everything figured out. The fellow student who founded an AI startup at twenty-two. The designer who claims to earn more than ever with AI. The influencer who says only the top one percent still have a chance.

What you see is a selection of other people's best moments. What you don't see are their doubts, their failures, the rejected applications and the days when they didn't know what to do either. Compare your inside with other people's outside, and you will always lose.

A better measure: *Am I a little further along than I was three months ago?* That question you can answer honestly, and you can influence the answer.

Separating what you can control

When your thoughts start to spin, a simple exercise helps. Draw a line down the middle of a page.

On the left, write everything you cannot control: how fast AI improves, the economy, interest rates, the hiring policies of large companies, what other people say about the future.

On the right, write everything you can: what you learn this week, who you talk to, what you build, how you spend your evenings, how well you sleep, how you treat yourself when something goes wrong.

The left side deserves your attention, because it is the environment you work in. It doesn't deserve your worry, because worry doesn't change it. The right side deserves your energy.

Anxious people tend to spend most of their mental energy on the left side of the page. Moving even part of it to the right side is one of the most effective things you can do.

Action against paralysis

The best remedy for paralysis is a small, concrete step. Not *"I need to rethink my career"*, but *"Tonight I will try one AI tool on one real task"* or *"Tomorrow I will message one person who works in the field I'm interested in."*

Small steps create real experiences, which convince the brain more than any amount of reading. They produce small results, which build confidence. And they generate new information that helps you decide what to do next.

A useful rule: **if you have spent more than thirty minutes reading about the future of work, stop and spend ten minutes doing something for your own.**

From threat to challenge

Psychologists distinguish between experiencing a difficult situation as a *threat*, where it seems dangerous and we feel we lack the resources to cope, or as a *challenge*, where it seems demanding but we believe we have, or can build, what it takes.

The external situation can be identical. What differs is how we read it and what we believe about our ability to respond. That belief is not fixed; it grows with every small success.

This is not forced positive thinking. Parts of the current situation are genuinely hard. It is about asking a different question: not *"What if I fail?"* but *"What is the next thing I could try that would make me more capable?"*

Basics that are easy to forget

It sounds banal, but it's true: sleep, movement and contact with other people strongly influence how threatening the future looks. The same situation looks different after a good night's sleep and a conversation with a friend.

Talk to friends, colleagues or family about your worries. Many will feel similar, and saying a worry out loud often makes it smaller. Many universities and employers offer free counselling or advice services; they are not only for crises, but also for phases when you have lost your direction.

If worries dominate your daily life over a longer period, if you can't sleep, can't concentrate or feel persistently low, talking to a professional is a sign of good judgement, not of weakness. There is no prize for struggling alone.

> **STORY · LENA**
>
> That night, Lena slept for nine hours. The next day, she did one small thing: she took the twelve Compass questions and looked at her lowest score in Part B. *I could explain to a friend what AI is good at and what it is bad at.* She had given herself a 2.

So she spent forty minutes testing three AI tools on three of her old university assignments and wrote down, honestly, where each one had been brilliant and where each one had been confidently wrong. It wasn't much. But it was the first thing in weeks that she had *done* rather than read.

YOUR COMPASS

Watcher: Ask yourself honestly whether "it doesn't concern me" is a calm assessment or a way of avoiding an uncomfortable topic. Both are human. Only one is useful.

Worrier: This chapter is especially for you. Do the control exercise today, not tomorrow. Then choose one action from the right-hand side that takes less than thirty minutes.

Explorer: Notice whether your activity is moving you forward or just keeping you busy. Starting new things can be a way of avoiding the question: *what do I actually want?*

Navigator: You don't have to keep up with everything. Choose what to follow and deliberately ignore the rest. Rest is not falling behind; it is how you stay able to steer.

MISSION 4 · DRAW THE LINE

Do the control exercise. On the left, what you cannot control. On the right, what you can.

Then circle one item on the right that you can act on in the next 48 hours, define a first step that takes no more than thirty minutes, and write down exactly when you will do it.

Outside my control	Within my control

My first step and when I'll do it

Key Takeaways

- Uncertainty is a normal reaction to an unclear situation, not a personal failure.
- Each profile tends to experience the change differently: avoidance, fear, restless activity or pressure.

- Compare yourself with your earlier self, not with other people's highlights.
- Put your energy on the side of the page you can influence.
- Sleep, movement and other people matter. Asking for help is a strength.

PART THREE

Grow

CHAPTER 5

The Skills That Gain Value

STORY · AMARA

The training session on Monday was exactly as boring as Amara had expected. A man from the software company showed slides about efficiency. Then they tried the system.

During a practice handover, Amara described a patient: an elderly man, recovering well after surgery, but more withdrawn than the day before, eating less, not asking about his daughter as he usually did. The system listened and produced a neat summary in seconds.

Patient stable. Post-operative recovery progressing as expected. No acute concerns.

Amara read it and felt her jaw tighten. "That's wrong," she said out loud.

The trainer looked surprised. "Which part?"

"All of it is technically correct. And it misses the only thing that matters. He's not himself. In my experience, that's how delirium starts, or depression, or an infection before the fever. Anyone reading this note would walk past his room."

The room went quiet. Then the ward manager said, "So the system needs someone who knows what to look for."

"The system," Amara said, "needs a nurse."

Later, she realised something surprising. The tool *had* saved time on the routine parts: medication, vital signs,

> wound status, all correctly documented. What it couldn't do was the part that had taken her twelve years to learn.

When a machine can do certain tasks cheaply, those tasks lose market value. At the same time, the value of everything the machine cannot do, and everything that makes the machine useful, goes up. That is where you should invest.

This chapter describes seven skills that fit that description. None of them is new. What is new is how much they matter, and they apply whether you write code, care for patients, run a business or design brands.

1. Understanding problems before solving them

The most expensive solution is one that solves a problem nobody has. People who can figure out what a customer, patient, user or client really needs have always been valuable. With AI, they become even more valuable, because *producing* solutions gets faster and cheaper while deciding *what* to produce does not.

A simple technique is to ask "why?" several times. A client asks Jonas for a new logo. Why? Because they want to look more modern. Why? Because younger customers aren't coming in. Why? Because nobody under thirty knows the shop exists. Suddenly the real problem isn't the logo; it's visibility. Jonas, who understands that, is worth far more than a tool that produces logos.

Before any task, write down in two or three sentences who it is for and what problem it solves. It feels slow at first. Over time it becomes the habit that separates experienced professionals from beginners.

2. Judgement and a sense for quality

AI produces results at high speed. Someone has to decide whether they are good. Is the code secure? Is the summary accurate, or did it quietly drop the most important detail, as in Amara's handover? Does the design actually fit the brand? Is the menu description honest about what's on the plate?

That judgement only comes from real understanding. This is why it is a mistake to think you no longer need to learn the fundamentals of your field because AI "knows" them. The opposite is true: people who understand the fundamentals can check AI output. People who don't are at the mercy of its mistakes and often don't even notice them.

3. Solid fundamentals

Every field has its foundations. In computer science: algorithms, data structures, operating systems, networks, databases, security. In nursing: physiology, pharmacology, clinical assessment. In design: composition, typography, colour, visual communication. In running a business: costs, margins, cash flow, customers.

Fundamentals often feel dry compared to the latest tools. But tools change every few years, and fundamentals stay remarkably stable. Someone who understands the basics can learn any new tool quickly. Someone who only knows the

tool is lost when it changes.

Fundamentals are also what makes AI useful to you. If you understand the concept, you can give precise instructions, notice when the output is going in the wrong direction and fill in what it leaves out.

4. Communication

When many people can produce similar results with AI, the difference often lies in who can explain, persuade and listen. Can you tell a manager in three sentences why a project will take longer? Can you explain to a worried relative what is happening to their father? Can you present a design concept so the client feels understood? Can you write a message that someone can act on immediately?

Communication includes listening. Many problems at work are not technical at all; they are misunderstandings between people who thought they meant the same thing.

It is also directly connected to working with AI. People who can say clearly what they want get better results from AI tools, because writing a good request for a colleague and writing a good prompt are closely related skills.

5. Domain knowledge

A computer scientist who understands healthcare, logistics or restaurants is far more valuable to those industries than a pure generalist. A designer who understands a particular industry deeply can advise clients in ways a tool cannot. A nurse who understands technology can shape how it's introduced on the ward.

AI produces generic answers well. What it can't easily provide is deep knowledge of why a hospital's problems differ from an airline's, or why a family restaurant's margins work differently from a chain's.

Domain knowledge grows from curiosity and contact: part-time jobs, internships, conversations with people in other professions, side projects for real users. Often a good niche is closer than you think: a family business, a previous job, a hobby, a community you belong to.

6. Taking ownership

A machine can perform a task. It cannot take responsibility for it. People who say *"I'll take care of this, and I'll make sure it works"* are wanted everywhere.

Ownership means noticing problems before someone asks, following through when things get difficult, admitting mistakes early and caring about the outcome rather than just the output. You can show it at any stage: organising a group project, maintaining something real that other people use, taking responsibility for a process at work, running a club or a small venture.

7. Learning fast

Perhaps the most important skill is the meta-skill: learning how to learn. When tools change every few months, the winner is not the person who knows the most, but the one who gets up to speed fastest with something new. Chapter 7 is entirely about this.

The combination is what counts

None of these skills alone makes you irreplaceable. Their value comes from combination. A developer with solid fundamentals, clear communication and knowledge of healthcare is in a very different position from one with only a list of programming languages. A nurse with clinical experience and confidence with digital tools may become exactly the person a hospital needs to introduce technology safely.

The large employer surveys point in the same direction: the profiles expected to be most in demand combine technical skills with human strengths like analytical thinking, resilience and creativity.

> **YOUR COMPASS**
>
> **Watcher:** You likely already have strong domain knowledge and ownership. Those are exactly the skills that become *more* valuable. Your growth area is usually confidence with digital tools; even a little goes a long way.
>
> **Worrier:** Fundamentals and judgement are your foundation. Instead of trying to compete with AI on speed, become the person who can tell whether AI output is right. That skill is in demand.
>
> **Explorer:** Your curiosity is learning fast in action. Now add depth: pick one domain and one skill on this list and go deep enough to be genuinely good.
>
> **Navigator:** Look at skills 1, 2, 4 and 6: understanding problems, judgement, communication and ownership.

These are the skills that move you from producing to directing. Invest in them deliberately.

MISSION 5 · YOUR SKILL PROFILE

Rate yourself from 1 (weak) to 5 (strong) on each of the seven skills. Be honest; nobody else needs to see this.

Understanding problems	1	2	3	4	5
Judgement and quality	1	2	3	4	5
Fundamentals of my field	1	2	3	4	5
Communication	1	2	3	4	5
Domain knowledge	1	2	3	4	5
Taking ownership	1	2	3	4	5
Learning fast	1	2	3	4	5

Now choose **one** skill you rated 2 or 3. Write down one concrete thing you will do in the next four weeks to improve it.

Key Takeaways

- Invest in what AI cannot do, and in what makes AI useful.
- Fundamentals matter more than ever, because you need them to judge AI output.
- Communication, domain knowledge and ownership are real competitive advantages in every field.
- The combination of technical and human skills is what makes you hard to replace.

CHAPTER 6

Working With AI – Practical Workflows

STORY · KARIM AND LENA

The box of receipts sat on the table between them. Six months of supplier invoices, crumpled and coffee-stained.

"I tried an app that reads receipts," Karim said. "And one that makes social media posts. And one that plans staff schedules. And one that designs menus." He counted on his fingers. "None of them changed anything."

"Because you didn't ask a question," Lena said. "You just tried tools."

"What question should I ask?"

Lena thought about it. "What's the biggest problem in the restaurant? Not the most interesting one. The biggest one."

Karim didn't hesitate. "Waste. Every week I throw away food. I order too much because I'm afraid of running out. My margin is small. If I could waste less, it would change everything."

"Then that's the question," Lena said. "How much do you order, how much do you sell, and where's the gap?"

They spent the evening typing the receipts into a spreadsheet, with an AI tool helping to read the blurry ones and Lena checking every number. By eleven o'clock they had the first chart. Karim stared at it.

> "Fresh herbs," he said slowly. "I'm throwing away almost half of the herbs I buy. Every week."
>
> It wasn't magic. It was one question, real data and someone who checked the results. But for the first time, a tool had changed something.

The people who benefit most from AI are not the ones who fear it or ignore it. Nor, as Karim discovered, are they the ones who try every tool. They are the people who use AI **on purpose, on real problems, and check the results**. This chapter shows practical ways to do that, whatever your work, and an honest look at where AI can slow you down.

The ground rule: you are the boss

Treat AI like a very fast, very well-read assistant who occasionally talks confident nonsense. You set the direction, you check the results and you carry the responsibility. If you accept output without checking it, you are not just handing over work; you are handing over control.

Start with the problem, not the tool

Karim's first approach is common: download tools and hope something useful happens. It rarely does. A better sequence:

1. **Name the problem.** What takes too much time, costs too much money or causes the most frustration?
2. **Describe what "better" looks like.** Faster? Fewer mistakes? Less waste? More customers?
3. **Then ask how AI could help** with that specific problem.

4. **Measure the result.** Did it actually improve?

A surprising finding: feeling faster is not the same as being faster

In 2025, the research organisation METR ran a carefully controlled experiment. Sixteen experienced software developers worked on 246 real tasks from large projects they knew very well. For each task, it was randomly decided whether they were allowed to use AI tools.

Before the study, the developers expected AI to make them about **24 percent faster**. Afterwards, they still believed it had made them about **20 percent faster**. The measurements showed the opposite: with AI, tasks took about **19 percent longer**. They spent less time doing the work itself and more time writing prompts, waiting, reviewing suggestions and fixing output that was almost, but not quite, right.

The researchers stress that this applies to a specific situation, experts in complex, familiar projects, and that tools are improving quickly. AI tends to help more with unfamiliar tasks, smaller projects and getting started. But the lesson applies to everyone: **don't trust your feeling of productivity. Measure it.**

Workflow 1: Learning with AI

AI can be an excellent study partner, if it trains your understanding instead of replacing it.

1. **Try first.** Read the material or attempt the task yourself before asking.

2. **Explain it back.** Describe what you understood and ask the AI to find gaps.
3. **Change the level.** Ask for explanations from simple to technical.
4. **Ask for practice, not solutions.** Solve exercises before looking at answers.
5. **Verify.** Check important points against reliable sources.

> *I'm learning about [topic]. Here is my explanation in my own words: [your explanation]. Don't rewrite it. Point out what is wrong, unclear or missing, and ask me one question that tests whether I really understood it.*

Workflow 2: Writing and communicating

Emails, reports, applications, menus, patient information, social media posts: AI helps with structure and wording. The best approach is to write a rough draft with your own thoughts first, then ask for criticism and improvement.

Letting AI write first often produces smooth, interchangeable text, like Karim's "soulful embrace of slow-cooked tenderness". Readers notice. Your own voice is an advantage.

> *Here is my draft [email / letter / post]. Tell me which sentences sound generic, which claims need a concrete example and where it could be shorter. Keep my tone. Don't rewrite it completely.*

Workflow 3: Admin and routine work

This is where many hands-on professionals get the most immediate value: scheduling, documentation, forms, ordering, standard letters, summaries of long documents.

1. Pick one recurring task that you dislike.
2. Write down the steps you normally follow.
3. Ask the AI to help with the most repetitive step, not the whole task at once.
4. Check every result, especially numbers, names, dates and anything with legal or safety consequences.

> *Here are this week's notes from my small business: [notes]. Summarise them into a list of open tasks, grouped by urgency. Don't add anything that isn't in the notes.*

Workflow 4: Analysing your own data

Karim's herbs show how powerful simple analysis can be. You don't need to be a data scientist to ask good questions of your own numbers: sales, expenses, time spent, customer feedback, grades.

> *Here is a table of my weekly orders and sales for the past three months: [data]. Which items show the biggest gap between what I buy and what I sell? Show your calculation so I can check it.*

Always ask the AI to show its working, and spot-check the numbers yourself. AI can make arithmetic and reading mistakes, especially with messy data.

Workflow 5: Creating and designing

For designers, writers and anyone producing creative work, AI can generate variations, drafts and ideas at enormous speed. The risk, as Jonas learned, is that speed becomes the only thing you sell.

Use AI to explore more possibilities and to handle repetitive production work. Keep the decisions that give the work its identity: the concept, the direction, the choice of what to keep and what to throw away.

> *I'm developing a visual identity for a family restaurant that has existed for twenty years and wants to attract younger customers without losing regulars. Give me ten different conceptual directions, each in two sentences. No images yet.*

Workflow 6: Programming

1. **Plan.** Describe the problem and ask for possible approaches with pros and cons. Decide yourself.
2. **Small steps.** Generate code in manageable pieces, not whole systems.
3. **Understand.** Read every line. Ask for explanations before accepting anything.
4. **Test.** Write tests and check that they test the right thing.
5. **Review.** Focus on security, error handling and edge cases.

> *Review the following code as a strict senior developer. Focus on security issues, unhandled errors and edge cases. List each issue with a short explanation. Don't rewrite the whole code.*

Workflow 7: A thinking partner for decisions

AI can help you think through decisions by arguing the other side. This works especially well when you already have an opinion.

> *I'm considering [decision]. My reasons are: [reasons]. Argue against this decision as convincingly as you can, then list the questions I should answer before deciding.*

The goal is not to let AI decide, but to see angles you might have missed.

Writing good instructions

- **Give context:** Who are you, what is the goal, who is the result for?
- **Be specific:** Format, length, constraints.
- **Show examples:** A good and a bad example explain more than long descriptions.
- **Say what you don't want:** "No images yet", "don't rewrite it", "don't add anything new".
- **Iterate:** The first answer is a draft. Give feedback and improve it.

Rules and boundaries

- **Follow your institution's rules.** Universities, hospitals and companies often have specific policies about AI use.
- **Protect confidential data.** Never paste patient information, customer data or company secrets into public AI tools unless this is explicitly allowed and secure.

- **Disclose AI use** where it is expected, for example in academic work or certain publications.
- **Respect copyright and licences**, especially for images and code used commercially.

YOUR COMPASS

Watcher: Start with Workflow 3. Pick the one administrative task you dislike most and try AI on a single step of it. Keep it small and safe, with no confidential data.

Worrier: Start with Workflow 1. Using AI to deepen your own understanding turns it from a competitor into a training partner.

Explorer: Follow Karim's lesson: one real problem, one tool, measured results. Workflow 4 is a great place to start.

Navigator: Remember the METR study. Measure where AI truly speeds you up and where it only feels like it does. Then use Workflows 5 and 7 to shift your time from producing to directing.

MISSION 6 · ONE PROBLEM, ONE WORKFLOW

Choose the biggest problem in your work or studies that AI might help with. Not the most exciting one, the biggest one. Pick one workflow from this chapter and use it at least three times over the next two weeks.

The problem I'm working on

Date	What I asked	Time incl. checking	Better, worse or same?

Key Takeaways

- Start with a real problem, not with a tool.
- Feeling more productive is not the same as being more productive. Measure it.
- Let AI train you and support you, but keep the judgement and decisions.
- Clear instructions and iteration lead to much better results.
- Protect confidential data and follow the rules of your institution.

CHAPTER 7

Learning That Lasts

STORY · JONAS

Jonas had always been a good learner, at least when it came to tools. New design software? He mastered it in a weekend. New AI image generator? He was producing professional results within hours. He had folders full of tutorials and a long list of skills on his website.

But after the evening with his spreadsheet, he understood that his problem wasn't a missing tool. It was a missing *depth*. He knew how to make things. He didn't know enough about why brands work, how customers decide, how to run a workshop that gets a client to say what they really want.

So he did something unusual for him: he stopped learning tools for a while. He bought two books on brand strategy, signed up for a short course on facilitation, and asked an older designer he admired whether he could sit in on one of her client workshops.

"It's strange," he told Karim. "For the first time in years, I'm learning something that's slow."

"Slow is good," Karim said, stirring a pot. "Fast food is cheap. Slow food you can charge for."

There was a time when people could finish an education and live off that knowledge for decades. That picture was inaccurate long before AI. Today it is over. The good news:

learning is a skill, and skills can be trained.

Thinking in a T shape

Picture the letter T. The horizontal bar is broad general knowledge: you roughly understand how technology, business, people and your own field fit together. The vertical bar is real depth in one or two areas.

Breadth alone makes you replaceable, because you're not really good at anything specific. Depth alone makes you vulnerable, because your speciality might change or shrink. The combination makes you adaptable: breadth helps you notice change early and connect ideas, depth gives you something others need.

AI makes the T shape more important. AI tools are extremely broad but often shallow in specific contexts. People who combine broad understanding with deep, practical expertise can direct those tools far better than people who have only one or the other.

Jonas had plenty of breadth in tools, but his depth was in *production*, the part AI was getting good at. He is now deliberately building depth in *strategy and client understanding*, the part it isn't.

Learning by doing

The fastest way to truly understand something is to use it on something real. Tutorials and courses create a feeling of progress, but only real application shows where you actually stand. In a tutorial, every step is prepared. In real work, you make decisions, deal with problems nobody predicted and

connect pieces that were never explained together.

Good learning projects have three properties:

- **They solve a real problem**, ideally your own or that of someone you know.
- **They are small enough** to finish within a few weeks.
- **They are big enough** that you hit problems no tutorial covers.

A finished small project is worth more than ten unfinished large ones. It also proves what employers and clients look for: that you can bring things to completion.

Project ideas for different kinds of people:

- **Student:** a tool that automates a real task for a real person, a club, a family business or a part-time employer.
- **Nurse or care worker:** a better handover checklist, a patient information sheet, a small improvement project on your ward.
- **Small business owner:** one measurable improvement, such as less waste, faster ordering or a better booking process.
- **Creative professional:** a case study that shows your thinking process, not just the final image.

Just in time, on a solid base

Many people try to learn everything they might need someday. That leads to overload and shallow knowledge. A better strategy: learn fundamentals in advance, and everything else at the moment you need it for something concrete.

AI is excellent for this just-in-time learning. If you already understand the underlying concepts, it can get you productive with a new tool or topic in hours instead of days. Note the condition: *if you already understand the concepts*. Just-in-time learning works on top of a foundation, not instead of one.

How learning actually sticks

Learning research offers a few reliable principles that most people underuse:

- **Retrieval:** Testing yourself beats re-reading. Close the book and explain or reproduce what you learned.
- **Spacing:** Reviewing over days and weeks beats cramming.
- **Mixing:** Practising different types of problems in one session forces you to think about which approach fits.
- **Explaining:** If you can explain something simply, you understand it. If you can't, you've found a gap.

AI can support all four: it can quiz you, mix practice problems or play a beginner you have to explain things to. Just make sure *you* do the thinking.

A simple learning system

Learning lasts when it doesn't depend on luck or motivation. A small system is enough:

- **Fixed time:** a few hours a week reserved only for learning and building, treated like an appointment.
- **Notes in your own words:** write as if explaining to someone else.

- **A weekly review:** what did I learn, what didn't work, what's next?
- **Few, good sources:** two newsletters you actually read are better than twenty that only make you anxious.

Learn with people, not only from screens

Some of the most valuable knowledge, the tacit knowledge from Chapter 3, can only be learned from people. Jonas sitting in on an experienced designer's workshop will teach him things no course can. Amara learned to recognise "not himself" from years beside experienced colleagues. Lena will learn more in three months of real work than in a year of tutorials.

Look for ways to learn next to experienced people: internships, mentoring, shadowing, volunteering, joining communities, working on shared projects. If you are experienced yourself, consider passing it on. Teaching is one of the best ways to deepen your own understanding.

Learning in public

People who share what they learn, learn twice. A short post, a project write-up or a talk at a local meetup forces you to be clear. It also creates a visible record of your growth that employers, clients and contacts can find.

Learning in public doesn't mean pretending to be an expert. It means sharing honestly: *"Here's what I tried, here's what went wrong, here's what I learned."* That kind of honesty is rare and memorable.

YOUR COMPASS

Watcher: Your deepest knowledge probably came from experience and from people, not from screens. Keep that, and add one small digital skill at a time, learned on a real task.

Worrier: Choose one small project and finish it. A completed project is the strongest antidote to the feeling of being behind.

Explorer: You already learn fast. Your growth is in depth. Choose your vertical bar of the T and commit to it for the next three months.

Navigator: Like Jonas, ask whether your depth lies in the part of your work AI is getting good at. If so, start building depth in judgement, strategy or domain knowledge now, while your current skills still pay.

MISSION 7 · DESIGN YOUR LEARNING SYSTEM

Answer these questions and put the time slots in your calendar today.

My T shape: my area of depth will be

My learning project (real problem, finishable in a few weeks)

My two fixed weekly time slots

Where I will keep my notes

A person I could learn from directly

Key Takeaways

- Combine broad knowledge with real depth in one area, ideally an area AI can't easily do.
- Learn by doing real things, and finish what you start.
- Build on solid fundamentals and learn the rest just in time.
- Use proven techniques: retrieval, spacing, mixing and explaining.
- Learn from people, not only from screens.

PART FOUR

Move

CHAPTER 8

Choosing Your Path

STORY · AMARA

Three weeks after the training, the ward manager called Amara into her office.

"The documentation pilot is going better than expected," she said. "Mostly because of you. The others trust the system more since you started checking the summaries and showing them what to watch for. Management wants each ward to have a 'digital champion'. Someone who trains colleagues, reports problems and helps decide how the tools are used." She paused. "I'd like it to be you."

Amara didn't answer immediately. Part of her was flattered. Part of her was suspicious. She had become a nurse to care for people, not to explain software.

That evening, at Karim's, she put the question to the others. "Is this a step forward or a step away from what I actually do?"

"What would you be doing?" Jonas asked.

"Still nursing, most of the time. But also deciding how these tools are used. Making sure they don't miss what that system missed with my patient."

Lena put down her fork. "So you'd be the person who makes sure the technology serves the patients, instead of the other way round."

> Amara was quiet for a moment. "When you put it like that," she said, "it sounds like nursing."

There is no single right path. There are different paths with different opportunities, risks and requirements. This chapter presents four basic directions. They are not mutually exclusive; many careers combine them, one after the other or at the same time.

Path 1: Grow where you are

The most underrated path is to change *within* your current work. Every organisation introducing AI needs people who understand both the work and the technology: who can test tools, train colleagues, spot problems and shape how things are done.

That person is rarely an outside consultant. It's usually someone like Amara: an experienced practitioner who is willing to engage.

Growing where you are can mean:

- Volunteering for pilot projects and new initiatives.
- Becoming the person colleagues ask about new tools.
- Taking on responsibility for a process that is being changed.
- Documenting what works and what doesn't, and sharing it.

This path is especially valuable for Watchers, whose deep practical knowledge is exactly what responsible introduction of AI requires.

Path 2: Get your first position

For students and career starters, the first job matters enormously. It is where most tacit knowledge is learned, by working next to people who already have it. As Chapter 3 showed, this first step has become harder in AI-exposed fields. That makes a deliberate approach more important.

What helps:

- **Demonstrable work.** Real projects, finished and explained, say more than a list of skills.
- **Practical experience during your studies.** Working-student jobs and internships are often the most direct route to a permanent position. Many companies hire their interns.
- **Targeted applications.** A few well-researched applications that show you understand the company beat hundreds of generic ones.
- **People.** Many positions are filled through recommendations. More on this in Chapter 9.
- **Looking wider.** Large tech companies are only one part of the market. Hospitals, logistics firms, manufacturers, public administration, banks, insurers, energy providers and many small and medium-sized companies all need technical people, often with much less competition.

Path 3: Specialise

Specialists are needed when problems are too difficult, too risky or too important for generalists. Some areas likely to gain importance:

- **Security:** more software and more automation mean more ways to attack.
- **Data:** AI is only as good as the data it works with.
- **Infrastructure and operations:** systems must run reliably and affordably.
- **Systems that touch the physical world:** medical devices, vehicles, machines and energy systems, where reliability and safety are critical.
- **Applied AI in a specific domain:** health, law, education, logistics, hospitality and more.
- **Quality and evaluation:** checking what AI produces, systematically.
- **Strategy and direction in creative fields:** the move Jonas is making from producing to directing.

A specialisation doesn't have to last forever. You can choose one, gain experience and change later. What carries over is the habit of going deep.

To choose, ask yourself three questions: Which tasks did I enjoy even when they were hard? Which problems do I think about when nobody asks me to? Where do my interests overlap with real, growing demand?

Path 4: Build something of your own

AI lowers the cost of starting. One person can now do things that used to require a small team. That opens possibilities:

- **Freelancing:** development, design, consulting or automation for small and medium-sized businesses.

- **Products:** apps, tools or services for a clearly defined group of people.
- **Digitising traditional businesses:** many restaurants, workshops, practices and shops have unsolved digital problems and nobody who understands them. Someone who combines technical skill with real knowledge of how these businesses run can create a lot of value. Lena helping Karim is a small example.
- **Strengthening an existing business:** for owners like Karim, the opportunity is not a new business, but using AI to run the current one better.

Self-employment has real downsides: irregular income, bureaucracy, taxes, insurance and the need to market yourself constantly. A realistic approach is to start small and on the side, and grow only once it carries itself. Before bigger steps, get advice; many chambers of commerce, business support organisations and university start-up centres offer it for free.

Combinations are normal

Many good careers aren't straight lines. Someone gets a first job, builds a small side project, specialises later and eventually becomes self-employed. Or someone freelances during their studies and then joins one of their clients. Combinations can also reduce risk: a stable job plus a small side project gives security and room to experiment at the same time.

How to find your path

Instead of brooding, test your assumptions on a small scale. Three questions help:

1. **Energy:** Which tasks make me forget the time, and which exhaust me?
2. **Risk:** How much financial uncertainty can I and do I want to handle right now?
3. **Environment:** Do I work best alone or with others, with structure or with freedom?

Then try something real: a pilot project, an internship, a small freelance job, a weekend project, a conversation with someone in the field. Real experience answers these questions better than any amount of thinking.

> **YOUR COMPASS**
>
> **Watcher:** Path 1 is made for you. Your experience is exactly what responsible introduction of AI needs. Say yes to the next pilot project, or propose one.
>
> **Worrier:** Path 2 is likely your focus. Combine it with Path 4 in a small way: a real project for a real person can become the evidence that gets you hired.
>
> **Explorer:** Path 4 may attract you, but remember your blind spot. Choose one business idea or one improvement project and commit to it for three months before starting another.
>
> **Navigator:** Path 3 is your strongest lever. Specialise in the part of your field where judgement and responsibility matter most, not where production is fastest.

MISSION 8 · THREE CONVERSATIONS

Over the next four weeks, have three short conversations: one with someone employed in a role you find interesting, one with someone specialised in a field you are considering, and one with someone self-employed or running a business.

Ask each person: *What does a typical week look like? What has changed because of AI? What would you do if you were starting today?*

Conversation 1: who, and the most important thing I learned

Conversation 2: who, and the most important thing I learned

Conversation 3: who, and the most important thing I learned

Which conversation gave me the most energy, and why?

Key Takeaways

- There are four basic paths: grow where you are, get your first position, specialise, or build something of your own.
- Growing where you are is underrated, especially for experienced practitioners.
- Look beyond the most famous employers; many sectors need people who combine technology with other knowledge.
- Paths can be combined. Test them on a small scale before making big decisions.

CHAPTER 9

Becoming Visible

STORY · LENA AND KARIM

The herb chart had grown into something bigger. Over six weeks, Lena had turned the spreadsheet into a small web app: Karim entered his daily sales on his phone, and every Thursday the app suggested how much to order from each supplier, with a short explanation for each number. She had used AI to write parts of the code, but she had read every line, tested it with real data and rewritten the parts that didn't make sense.

The restaurant's food waste had dropped noticeably. Karim showed the app to everyone who would look.

One Thursday morning, the driver from Karim's wholesale supplier arrived with the delivery, and the regional manager came along to discuss prices. Karim showed him the order suggestions on his phone.

"Who built this?" the manager asked.

"Her," Karim said, pointing at Lena, who was cleaning tables. "She's a computer science student. Best one in the city."

The manager walked over. "We have two hundred restaurant customers who order exactly like Karim used to: too much, out of fear. Our own systems don't help them with that. Would you be willing to come and show this to our IT team?"

> Lena stood there with a wet cloth in her hand, trying to remember how to speak.
>
> "Yes," she said finally. "Yes, I would."

Skills that nobody sees don't open doors. In a market where entry-level positions are scarcer, clients are more cautious and everyone has access to the same AI tools, being visible is no longer optional.

Visibility doesn't mean becoming an influencer or posting every day. It means a small number of clear signals that tell the right people: *this person solves real problems, finishes things and is good to work with.*

Why signals matter more than ever

Look at it from the other side. An employer posts a position and receives hundreds of applications. Many look similar: the same qualifications, the same lists of skills, cover letters that sound polished but interchangeable, often because they were written with the same AI tools. A client looking for a designer sees dozens of portfolios full of similar, AI-assisted images.

What stands out? Usually one of three things:

- **Evidence of real work:** something that runs, is used, solved a problem or produced a measurable result.
- **A personal connection:** someone the employer or client already trusts vouches for you.
- **Specificity:** you clearly understand *this* organisation, *this* client, *this* problem.

All three are hard to fake. That is exactly why they work. Lena's story contains all three: a working app, a trusted person vouching for her and a specific problem the manager recognised.

Evidence of work, for every profession

The idea of a "portfolio" usually belongs to developers and designers. But everyone can collect evidence of their work:

- **Students and developers:** finished projects with clear explanations, contributions to shared projects, tools that real people use.
- **Designers and creatives:** case studies that show your *thinking*, not just the final result: the problem, the questions you asked, the options you rejected, the outcome.
- **Nurses, technicians and other practitioners:** improvement projects you led, training you gave, problems you identified and solved, responsibilities you took on. Write them down; they are easy to forget.
- **Business owners:** measurable improvements, customer feedback, problems solved, things you built.

For each piece of evidence, someone should be able to answer four questions within a minute:

1. **What was the problem?** Start with the problem, not the method.
2. **What did you do?** A short overview of your approach and key decisions.

3. **What was hard?** One real difficulty and how you handled it. This is where your thinking becomes visible.
4. **What was the result?** And what did you learn?

Three good pieces of evidence are worth more than fifteen weak ones.

Being honest about AI in your work

Employers and clients know you use AI tools. Hiding it makes little sense. What they want to know is whether *you* understand what you produced and can take responsibility for it.

Be ready to explain every important part of your work, including the parts AI helped with. If you can't explain it, it isn't really your evidence yet. A short, honest note, such as *"I used AI tools for parts of the code and for drafting; the analysis, architecture and testing are my own"*, often works in your favour. It shows that you use modern tools consciously and responsibly.

Building relationships without feeling fake

Many people dislike the word "networking". It sounds like collecting contacts for selfish reasons. Real networking is simpler: getting to know people who work on things you care about, and being useful to them where you can.

Approaches that work, even for people who are not naturally outgoing:

- **Start with people you already know.** Classmates, colleagues, former employers, teachers, customers,

suppliers. Lena's opportunity came through Karim's supplier.

- **Ask for advice, not favours.** *"Could I ask you three questions about your work?"* is easy to say yes to.
- **Be specific and brief.** A short message showing you have looked at someone's work gets more replies than a long, generic one.
- **Follow up and give back.** Thank people, tell them what came of their advice, share something useful.
- **Go where work happens.** Meetups, professional events, community projects and shared work make connecting easier than pure small talk.

When hiring becomes more selective, recommendations matter more. A person inside an organisation who says *"I've seen this person's work"* can move you from the large pile to the small one.

A message template

> *Hi [name], I'm a [your role] interested in [specific field]. I saw your [article / talk / project] about [specific topic] and found [specific point] really useful. I'm trying to understand how people approach [topic]. Would you be open to a 15-minute call, or answering two short questions by message? Either way, thanks for sharing your work.*

Many people won't answer. That's normal and not personal. Some will, and those conversations can change your direction.

Applications and proposals that stand out

For your CV or profile:

- Put your strongest evidence at the top.
- Describe results, not just responsibilities. *"Built an ordering tool that reduced a restaurant's weekly food waste"* beats *"Experience with web development"*.
- Keep it short. One page is usually enough early in a career.

For cover letters and proposals:

- Open with why *this* organisation or client, specifically.
- Connect one or two pieces of your evidence directly to what they need.
- End with a clear, friendly next step.

Use AI to check for clarity and mistakes. But the substance has to come from you. A letter that could be sent to any company won't stand out to this one.

Dealing with rejection

In a tight market, you will be rejected, often without explanation. That hurts. A few things help:

- Rejections are often about numbers, internal candidates or timing, not your worth.
- Every application and conversation is practice.
- Patterns are data. Rejected before interviews? Improve your evidence and targeting. Rejected after interviews? Practise and ask for feedback.

Keep a simple log: organisation, role, date, how far you got, what you learned. Over time, patterns appear, and patterns

can be worked on.

YOUR COMPASS

Watcher: You probably have more evidence than you think. Write down three situations where you solved a real problem or took responsibility. Those stories are valuable.

Worrier: Visibility can feel frightening. Start small: one well-documented project, one message to one person. Lena's breakthrough came from a real problem for a real person, not from her forty-third application.

Explorer: Turn your experiments into one strong case study. Finished and explained beats many and scattered.

Navigator: Show your thinking, not just your output. Case studies that reveal your judgement and decisions set you apart from people who only show what a tool produced.

MISSION 9 · MAKE YOUR WORK VISIBLE

Choose your strongest piece of evidence and describe it using the four questions. Then send one short, specific message to someone who works in the field you're interested in.

The problem

What I did

What was hard, and how I handled it

The result and what I learned

Who I'll contact, and when

Key Takeaways

- In a crowded market, evidence of real work, personal connections and specificity make the difference.
- Everyone can collect evidence of their work, not only developers and designers.
- Be honest about AI in your work, and be ready to explain everything you show.

- Networking means asking for advice, being specific and building relationships over time.
- Treat rejections as data, not as a verdict on your worth.

CHAPTER 10

Your 90-Day Plan

STORY · KARIM, AMARA, LENA AND JONAS

It was Karim's idea. It usually was.

"Ninety days," he announced on a quiet Monday evening, putting four glasses of tea on the table. "Every one of us does one thing. A real thing. And every Thursday, after closing, we sit here for half an hour and tell each other how it's going."

"Like a support group," Jonas said.

"Like a kitchen," Karim said. "Nobody cooks alone in a good kitchen."

Amara took out a pen. "My goal is to decide about the digital champion role properly. Not out of fear, and not out of flattery. After ninety days, I want to know whether it's right for me."

"Mine is to raise my rates," Jonas said. "By selling strategy instead of images. One client who pays for my thinking."

Lena took a deep breath. "A job. Or at least a real chance at one, through the wholesaler or somewhere else."

Everyone looked at Karim.

"Mine," he said, "is to finish one thing." He held up his phone. "I'm deleting six apps tonight."

Knowledge alone changes nothing. That is why this book doesn't end with a summary, but with a plan. Ninety days are long enough to see real progress and short enough to stay motivated.

Adapt the plan to your life. If you are in the middle of exams, night shifts or the busiest season of your business, stretch it. What matters is not perfection but regularity. Five focused hours a week over ninety days add up to more than sixty hours of deliberate work on your future. That is a lot.

Before you start

Take thirty minutes and write down honest answers:

My Compass profile today, and my scores

What worries me most about the future

What a good result after 90 days looks like (concrete!)

How many hours per week I can realistically invest

Who I'll share my progress with

A concrete result looks like *"one finished portfolio project and five targeted applications"*, *"one paying client for strategy work"* or *"a clear decision about a new role"*. *"Feel better about AI"* is too vague to plan for.

Find a partner. Karim's idea is backed by common sense: people who share their goals with others and report regularly are far more likely to follow through. A friend, colleague, fellow student or family member is enough. Thirty minutes a week, same time, same place.

Phase 1 (Days 1–30): See clearly

The goal: understand your situation and choose a direction.

Week 1: Orientation

- ☐ Take the Compass and complete Mission 1.
- ☐ Do the control exercise (Mission 4).
- ☐ Use an AI tool for at least fifteen minutes on most days, on real tasks.

Week 2: Your work and your market

- ☐ Map three of your tasks with and without AI (Mission 2).
- ☐ Read your market (Mission 3).

Week 3: Your skills and your people

- ☐ Complete your skill profile (Mission 5).
- ☐ Have at least two of the three conversations (Mission 8).

Week 4: Decide

☐ Choose a provisional direction: a path from Chapter 8 and a focus skill.

☐ Define the one real problem you will work on in Phase 2.

Phase 2 (Days 31–60): Build

The goal: one finished, real piece of work in your chosen direction.

Week 5: Plan

☐ Write a three-sentence problem statement: who it's for, what problem it solves, how you'll know it worked.

☐ Set up your learning system (Mission 7).

Weeks 6–7: Do the work

☐ Work in small steps, using one workflow from Chapter 6 (Mission 6).

☐ Close one gap in your fundamentals that the work reveals.

Week 8: Finish

☐ Finish it. "Finished" means usable, documented and shown to at least one person.

☐ Ask for honest feedback and improve one thing.

Phase 3 (Days 61–90): Become visible

The goal: make your work visible and open doors.

Week 9: Your evidence

☐ Describe your work with the four questions (Mission 9).

☐ Update your CV, profile, portfolio or business presence.

Weeks 10–11: Reach out

☐ Contact at least five people or organisations with a specific, personal message or application.

☐ Share what you learned: a post, a short talk, a conversation with your team.

Week 12: Look back

☐ Retake the Compass (Mission 10).

☐ Compare with your starting page. What changed? What surprised you? What's next?

Your profile's focus

The plan is the same for everyone, but each profile should pay attention to something different:

> **YOUR COMPASS**
>
> **Watcher:** In Phase 1, focus on Mission 2: discover where AI could help with the edges of your work. In Phase 2, choose an improvement project at your workplace. In Phase 3, make sure the right people know what you did.
>
> **Worrier:** In Phase 1, don't skip Mission 4. In Phase 2, choose a small project you can definitely finish; completion matters more than ambition. In Phase 3, reach out even if it feels uncomfortable. Especially then.
>
> **Explorer:** In Phase 1, resist starting anything new until Week 4. In Phase 2, stay with your one project even when a more exciting idea appears. Write the new ideas down for the next ninety days.
>
> **Navigator:** In Phase 1, measure where AI truly helps you. In Phase 2, choose work that shows judgement and

> direction, not just output. In Phase 3, lead with your thinking.

The weekly rhythm

- **Start of the week:** set three small, concrete goals.
- **During the week:** protect fixed time slots, even if they're short.
- **End of the week:** ten minutes of review, ideally with your partner.

Wk	Hours	What I finished	One thing I'm proud of
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			
12			

When things don't go to plan

There will be weeks when nothing moves. Exams, night shifts, illness, family, a busy season or simple tiredness get in the way. That's normal. The plan is a tool, not a judgement of you.

If you miss a week, start again at the next step. Don't try to catch up on everything at once, and don't restart from Day 1. People who keep going after a bad week get further than people who wait for the perfect fresh start.

If you keep skipping the same kind of task, that's useful information. Maybe the task is too big and needs to be split. Maybe it doesn't fit you and needs to be replaced. Adjust the plan; don't abandon it.

MISSION 10 · RETAKE THE COMPASS

At the end of your ninety days, go back to Chapter 1 and answer the twelve statements again, without looking at your old answers. Then compare.

Part A then now

Part B then now

Profile then now

The biggest change in these 90 days

My focus for the next 90 days

Remember: Part A usually changes slowly, because it describes your field. Part B is the one you control. If it went up, you moved.

Key Takeaways

- See clearly, build, become visible: in that order.
- One finished, real piece of work is the strongest proof of your abilities.
- A partner and a weekly rhythm keep the plan alive.
- Regularity beats perfection. After a bad week, simply take the next step.

Epilogue: Ninety Days Later

The last Thursday came on a warm evening. Karim had pushed two tables together and put out more food than four people could possibly eat. "Less waste in the kitchen," he explained, "so more for my friends."

They had kept the ritual. Not every week; there had been night shifts and deadlines and one Thursday when Karim's dishwasher broke and flooded the kitchen. But most weeks, after closing, they had sat here for half an hour and told each other the truth.

Lena went first. She had given the presentation to the wholesaler's IT team, nervous enough to forget her own name for a moment, and then calm once she started explaining the problem. Two weeks later, they offered her a working-student position in their digital team, twenty hours a week alongside her final semester, with the possibility of a full-time role after graduation. Her first task: building a proper version of Karim's ordering tool for their restaurant customers.

"It's not a miracle," she said. "I still got eleven more rejections during these ninety days. But this one came from something I actually built, for someone who actually used it."

She had retaken the Compass that morning. Part A: still twenty-six. Part B: twenty-two. "Navigator," she said, and it sounded strange in her mouth. "I'm still worried sometimes. But I'm not standing still."

Amara had accepted the role of digital champion, with conditions she had negotiated herself: protected hours each week, and a clear rule that any AI-generated note had to be checked by the nurse responsible for the patient. She had started a small list of "things the system misses" and shared it across the hospital. Two other wards had asked her to train their staff.

"I was so sure this had nothing to do with me," she said. "Now I think the opposite. If people like us don't get involved, people who don't understand patients will decide how these tools are used." Her Part B score had risen from ten to twenty. "Apparently I'm an Explorer now. My grandmother would laugh."

Jonas had raised his rates, carefully, for new clients only. More importantly, he had sold his first brand strategy workshop: a full day with the owners of a local bakery, before he had drawn a single line. They paid more for that day than for most of his previous logo projects. He still used AI tools every day, for variations, mock-ups and repetitive production work. But he no longer sold what the tools could make. He sold what he could see.

"My Compass profile didn't change," he said. "Still a Navigator. But I'm navigating in a different direction."

Then everyone looked at Karim.

He took out his phone and showed them the home screen. Four apps, down from eleven. Then he showed them a number: the amount he had spent on fresh produce in the last month compared to the same month a year ago. It was noticeably lower, and the restaurant had served more guests.

"I finished one thing," he said. Then he reached into his apron and pulled out a crumpled order pad, covered in handwriting. "And I have a list of ideas for the next ninety days. But only one of them is allowed to start on Monday."

They laughed. Then they raised their glasses of tea.

"To the next ninety days," Karim said.

Conclusion: Not Replaced, But Augmented

If you have read this far, you have already done something many people don't: you have faced the uncertainty instead of looking away from it. That is the real beginning.

Nobody can promise you what work will look like in five or ten years. Anyone who claims to know is selling something. The data in this book shows real pressure, especially at the start of careers, and it would be dishonest to pretend otherwise. But the same data shows something else: where AI strengthens people instead of replacing them, work holds up and grows.

Lena, Amara, Karim and Jonas are fictional. Their situations are not. Every day, real people are rejected from jobs they trained for, handed new tools they didn't ask for, overwhelmed by possibilities or watching their work change faster than they can adapt. And every day, some of them find a way to move: one honest look at where they stand, one small action, one finished piece of work, one conversation at a time.

Some things can be said with confidence. People who understand problems, take ownership, communicate well and keep learning will be needed. That was true before AI, and it will remain true with it. What has changed is how much these qualities matter, and how quickly people who neglect them

fall behind.

AI changes how we work. It takes tasks off our hands, some we enjoyed and many we didn't. It makes some skills less valuable and others more valuable. But it does not take away our decision about what to do with our time, our knowledge and our lives.

The title of this book is not an empty promise. It is an invitation. Whether AI replaces you or augments you depends to a large extent on how you meet it: as a threat that paralyses you, or as a tool you learn to master.

You don't have to solve everything at once. You only have to take the next step. Then the one after that. And at some point you'll look back and realise you have found your place, not although the world changed, but because you learned to change with it.

Good luck on your way.

APPENDIX A

Mission Log

Tick off each mission when you complete it. Write the date next to it.

- ☐ **Mission 1:** Take your bearings (Chapter 1)
- ☐ **Mission 2:** Map your tasks (Chapter 2)
- ☐ **Mission 3:** Read your market (Chapter 3)
- ☐ **Mission 4:** Draw the line (Chapter 4)
- ☐ **Mission 5:** Your skill profile (Chapter 5)
- ☐ **Mission 6:** One problem, one workflow (Chapter 6)
- ☐ **Mission 7:** Design your learning system (Chapter 7)
- ☐ **Mission 8:** Three conversations (Chapter 8)
- ☐ **Mission 9:** Make your work visible (Chapter 9)
- ☐ **Mission 10:** Retake the Compass (Chapter 10)

Completed all ten? Then you have done more for your future in ninety days than most people do in a year. Start the next round with a bigger goal.

APPENDIX B

Prompt Library

These prompts are starting points for any kind of work. Replace the parts in square brackets. One rule applies to all of them: **check the results**, and never enter confidential information about patients, customers or your employer into public AI tools.

For understanding and learning

Explain at three levels

> *Explain [concept] to me at three levels: first for a complete beginner, then for someone with basic knowledge of [field], then at an expert level. After each level, ask me one question to check my understanding.*

Check my understanding

> *Here is my explanation of [topic] in my own words: [explanation]. Don't rewrite it. Point out what is wrong, unclear or missing, and ask me one follow-up question.*

Practice problems

> *Create five practice problems on [topic], from easy to difficult, mixing different types. Don't show solutions until I ask.*

Learning map

> *I need to learn [topic] for [purpose]. Give me a learning map: the ten most important concepts in a sensible order, one sentence each, and a small real-world project to practise them.*

For writing and communication

Improve my draft

> *Here is my draft [email / letter / report / post]. Tell me which sentences are vague or generic, which claims need a concrete example and where it could be shorter. Keep my tone. Don't rewrite it completely.*

Prepare a difficult conversation

> *I need to talk to [person / role] about [situation]. My goal is [goal]. Help me prepare: what might they be worried about, what questions might they ask, and how could I open the conversation calmly?*

Explain simply

> *Explain the following to someone without any background in [field], in under 150 words, without jargon: [text or topic].*

For your work and business

Organise my notes

> *Here are my notes: [notes]. Turn them into a list of open tasks, grouped by urgency. Don't add anything that isn't in the*

> *notes.*

Analyse my numbers

> *Here is a table of [data]. What are the three most important patterns? Show your calculation step by step so I can check it.*

Find the real problem

> *A [customer / client / colleague] asked me for [request]. Help me find the underlying problem by asking me "why" questions one at a time.*

Improve a process

> *Here is how I currently do [task], step by step: [steps]. Which steps could be simplified, combined or supported by a tool? List risks for each suggestion.*

For creative work

Explore directions

> *I'm working on [project] for [client / audience], who wants to [goal]. Give me ten different conceptual directions, each in two sentences. No final designs yet.*

Critique my work

> *Here is a description of my [design / text / concept]: [description]. Critique it from the perspective of [target audience]. What is clear, what is confusing and what is*

> *missing?*

For code

Plan before coding

> *I want to build [description] for [user]. Suggest two or three approaches, each with advantages, risks and what I would need to learn. Don't write code yet.*

Strict review

> *Review this code as a strict senior developer. Focus on security, unhandled errors, edge cases and readability. List each issue with a short explanation. Don't rewrite the whole code.*

For your career

Interview practice

> *I have an interview for [role] at [type of organisation]. Ask me ten realistic questions, one at a time, including two about my experience and two about difficult situations. After each answer, give me short, honest feedback.*

Test a decision

> *I'm considering [decision]. My reasons are: [reasons]. Argue against it as convincingly as you can, then list the questions I should answer before deciding.*

Review my progress

> *Here are my notes from the past four weeks: [notes]. Summarise what I have achieved, point out patterns in what went well and what didn't, and suggest three priorities for the next four weeks.*

Sources

The figures in this book were checked against the following sources in October 2026. Labour market data changes regularly; please consult the latest versions.

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About the Author

Pouria Keshtidar is a computer science student and former backend developer. He started writing this book when he felt lost between AI, the job market and his own future, and noticed how many others were asking the same questions. *Not Replaced, But Augmented* is his attempt to find honest answers and share them.

He speaks German, English and Persian.

You can reach him at Pkeshtidar@gmail.com. If this book helped you, a short review on Amazon helps other readers find it.

How this book was made

This book was written with the support of AI tools, used for research, drafting and editing. The author chose the direction, reviewed the content and is responsible for it. In a book about being augmented rather than replaced, it seemed only right to say so.